

Stoa of Attalos

Location Athens, Greece

The modern version of the Stoa of Attalos, built in the 1950s, is a precise reconstruction of the original 2nd-century BCE structure destroyed in 267 CE. It formed one side of the agora, or marketplace, that was a prime focus of Athenian public life. The stoa is a substantial, two-story structure, measuring 377 ft (115 m) long and 66 ft (20 m) wide. Constructed of marble and limestone, it consists of a ground-floor colonnade fronted by fluted

▼ DORIC AND IONIC COLUMNS AT THE STOA OF ATTALOS

Doric columns and a smaller, upper colonnade with similarly fluted three-quarter Ionic columns. The precision of the stoa's craftsmanship highlights how Greek urban planning was increasingly directed toward ordered, composed public spaces.

Ostia's Insulae

Location Ostia, Italy

During Rome's early Imperial period (1st century CE), the growing importance of Ostia, on the mouth of the Tiber, as Rome's port led to a rapid increase in its population, which in turn

put great pressure on housing. As a result, there was a reduction in the number of private houses being built, and the creation of high-rise tenement blocks, or *insulae*—literally “islands” (the term also means a city block)—increased. Ostia has some of the best examples of this new type of domestic architecture. *Insulae* were often cheaply built of unadorned bricks and concrete, with poor sanitation. Because of the risk of fires, the least desirable rooms were those located on the upper floors. Fears over safety led to height restrictions—first to 70 ft (21 m), later to 60 ft (18 m). Nonetheless, *insulae* with as many as six stories were common.

Maison Carrée

Location Nîmes, France

Built around 19 BCE, the Maison Carrée (“square house”) is the most complete surviving Roman temple. It is raised on a substantial 10-ft- (3-m-) high podium and is reached by steps at the main west end flanked by the podium's arms. The deep portico, which is fronted by six fluted Corinthian columns, with two more on each side, is topped by a commanding pediment. Both sides of the walled, windowless temple feature eight Corinthian half-columns. An elaborate frieze, with tendrils and acanthus decorations, runs around the building. Like all the carvings

